A small beginning, a great miracle

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

נעשה בו נס והדליקו ממנו שמונה ימים

A miracle occurred with it, and they lit from it for eight days.

Shabbat 21b | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Gemara tells us that after the Chashmonaim defeated their enemies, they found only one container of oil bearing the Kohen Gadol's seal. It held enough for one day, yet it supplied eight days of light. Chanukah remembers Hashem's help and the return to serving Him in the Beit HaMikdash. Our family learning is also a small beginning: ten minutes in which we make room for Torah and for one another.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Tonight is Friday. Light Chanukah candles before Shabbat candles, before Shabbat begins. Prepare enough oil or long-lasting candles to burn until at least half an hour after nightfall. An adult should check local times. Print this sheet beforehand; discuss and answer aloud on Shabbat.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Tell the Chanukah story in three turns: the difficulty, the discovery, and the miracle. Each partner adds one part. Then each person names one thing that makes learning together enjoyable.

Younger learners: Hold up one finger, then eight. What changed?
Older learners: Why does the seal matter? How is remembering a miracle different from expecting a miracle to solve our problems?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. How many days could the oil naturally last? 2. How many days did it actually supply light?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Read the selections from Rambam 3:1-3 on the reverse. He describes both rescue from oppression and the oil. Explain how these two parts belong to the same celebration.

Sources: Shabbat 21b; Friday lighting: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1; Mishnah Berurah 679:2; Rambam 3:1-3.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Shabbat 21b | The oil miracle

Selected passage

שכשנכנסו יוונים להיכל טמאו כל השמנים שבהיכל וכשגברה מלכות בית חשמונאי ונצחום בדקו ולא מצאו אלא פך אחד של שמן שהיה מונח בחותמו של כהן גדול ולא היה בו אלא להדליק יום אחד נעשה בו נס והדליקו ממנו שמונה ימים לשנה אחרת קבעום ועשאום ימים טובים בהלל והודאה

When the Greeks entered the Sanctuary, they made all its oil impure. When the Chashmonaim overcame and defeated them, they searched and found only one container of oil bearing the Kohen Gadol's seal. It held enough to light for only one day. A miracle occurred, and they lit from it for eight days. The following year, they established these as festive days of praise and thanksgiving.

2. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:1-3 | Selections

Excerpts from 3:1, 3:2 and 3:3, in order; omissions marked

ולא הניחו אותם לעסוק בתורה ובמצוות ... עד שריחם עליהם אלהי אבותינו, והושיעם מידם והצילם ... ולא מצאו שמן טהור במקדש אלא פך אחד ולא היה בו להדליק אלא יום אחד בלבד והדליקו ממנו נרות המערכה שמונה ימים ... ומפני זה התקינו חכמים שבאותו הדור שיהיו שמונת ימים האלו שתחלתן כ"ה בכסליו ימי שמחה והלל

They did not allow them to study Torah and observe mitzvot ... until the God of our ancestors had mercy on them, saved them from their hands, and rescued them ... They found only one container of pure oil in the Temple, enough for just one day, and used it to light the lamps for eight days ... Therefore, the Sages of that generation established these eight days, beginning on 25 Kislev, as days of joy and praise.

3. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1 | Friday lighting

Selected passage

בערב שבת מדליקין נר חנוכה תחלה ואחר כך נר שבת.

On Friday afternoon, one lights the Chanukah lamp first, and afterward the Shabbat lamp.

4. Mishnah Berurah 679:2 | Enough fuel

Selected passage

וכבר כתבנו בשם האחרונים דצריך ליתן בה שמן עד שידלק חצי שעה אחר צאת הכוכבים וכן במדליק נרות

We have already written in the name of the later authorities that one must put in enough oil for it to burn until half an hour after nightfall. The same applies when lighting candles.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Compare the two miracles described by Rambam: rescue from oppression and the oil. Which words express our response? The selections above supply the passages needed for the front-side extension.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.